Robert McKercher, Economics Ph.D. Candidate, McMaster University

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Research Interests

Public Economics | Labour Economics | Experimental Economics | Taxation | Migration

Education

Ph.D. Economics | McMaster University | Expected completion: June 2027
M.A. Economics | McMaster University | 2021
B.A. Honours Economics with Research Specialization | Wilfrid Laurier University | 2019

Research

Job Market Paper

Taxing Income Splitting within Business-owning Families

Abstract: Business owners can reduce their family tax liability by paying dividends to lower-income spouses. Governments have long used tax rules to restrict this practice, but little is known about how families respond. Using linked personal, corporate, and payroll tax records, I study Canada's 2018 expansion of the Tax on Split Income rules. Among spouses reporting positive dividends, dividend income falls by 53% in the treated group relative to controls. Higher owner dividends offset 57% of the dollar decline in spouse dividends, and owner labour income also rises. The reform therefore primarily reallocates reported income within families. I estimate a spouse-dividend elasticity of 1.30 with respect to the relative net-of-tax return to paying the spouse rather than the owner. With access to the same income-shifting channel, families across income groups show similar estimated elasticities. This finding suggests that differences in access to tax planning may help explain the larger taxable-income elasticities often estimated for higher-income taxpayers.

Working Papers

Should I Stay or Should I Go? The Impact of Taxation on Canadian Inter-Provincial Migration
with Adam M. Lavecchia and Alisa Tazhitdinova
Reject and Resubmit, Journal of Public Economics (July 2026)

The Impact of Government Social Spending on the Elasticity of Taxable Income

Labour Supply Responses to Marginal Tax Rates, Average Tax Rates, and Tax Progressivity
with Li-Hsin Lin

Works in Progress

Poverty and Income Security in Canada: Designing a Canada-Wide Guaranteed Basic Income Using the PEI Proposal
with Robin Boadway, Kourtney Koebel, and Wayne Simpson

Teaching Experience

Instructor | McMaster University | Winter 2025
Intermediate Microeconomics II (EC2ZZ3)

Teaching Assistant | McMaster University | 2020–Present
Introductory Microeconomics; Introductory Macroeconomics; Intermediate Microeconomics I & II; Environmental Economics; Public Sector Economics: Taxation; International Monetary Economics; Labour Economics; Behavioural Economics

Conference Presentations

Should I Stay or Should I Go? The Impact of Taxation on Canadian Inter-Provincial Migration
Canadian Economic Association Annual Conference, Vancouver, British Columbia | May 2026

The Impact of Government Social Spending on the Elasticity of Taxable Income
Canadian Economic Association Annual Conference, Toronto, Ontario | May 2024

Research Experience

Research Assistant to Kourtney Koebel | University of Toronto | September 2026–Present

Research Assistant to Adam M. Lavecchia | McMaster University | 2021–2025
Research Assistant to Siha Lee | McMaster University | 2023
Research Assistant to Bradley Ruffle | McMaster University | 2022

Awards, Grants, Scholarships

David S. Daly Academic Grant | 2025–2026
Ontario Graduate Scholarship | 2024–2025
General Bursary | 2023–2024 & 2024–2025
McMaster Economics Graduate Scholarship | 2020–2025

Technical Skills

Stata | Fortran | Python | R | Excel

References

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